

MOVIE STILL FINDER

Version 1.0 User Manual

Find the right frame. Mark it. Export it.

A cross-platform desktop tool for reviewing movie clips, finding prompt-matched moments with OpenAI vision, curating timeline markers, and exporting still images.

IN THIS GUIDE

- Get the program from GitHub
- Install on macOS or Windows
- Configure PyCharm and your OpenAI API key
- Search one movie or many movies
- Review, adjust, and extract marked stills
- Understand every GUI control from A through AH

Repository: github.com/alenknight/Movie_Stills

1. Get the program

Option A - Download ZIP

Use this if you simply want a copy and do not need Git version history.

- Open github.com/alenknight/Movie_Stills
- Click Code, then Download ZIP
- Open the downloaded ZIP
- Move the Movie_Stills folder to your normal projects location

On macOS, a convenient location is Documents/PythonScripts. On Windows, Documents\PythonScripts works well.

Option B - Clone with Git

Use this if you want easy updates and version history.

```
git clone https://github.com/alenknight/Movie_Stills.git
cd Movie_Stills
```

Required project files

- movie_still_finder.py - the application
- requirements.txt - Python packages
- README.md - concise reference
- .env.example - safe API-key template
- Movie_Still_Finder_Help.pdf - this manual, when copied into the repository

Private repository note

If the repository is private, sign into the GitHub account that has access before downloading or cloning.

2. Install on macOS

Prerequisites

- Python 3.10 or newer
- An internet connection
- An OpenAI API account with API billing configured
- PyCharm is optional but recommended for this workflow

Open the project in PyCharm

- Start PyCharm
- Choose File > Open
- Select the Movie_Stills folder
- Choose New Window if another project is open

Create the environment

```
python3 -m venv .venv
source .venv/bin/activate
python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
python movie_still_finder.py
```

If python3 is unavailable

Install a current Python release from python.org/downloads, reopen Terminal, and try again.

PyCharm interpreter

Open PyCharm Settings > Project > Python Interpreter, choose Add Local Interpreter > Existing, then select .venv/bin/python.

3. Install on Windows

Prerequisites

- Python 3.10 or newer
- Enable Add Python to PATH during Python installation
- An internet connection
- An OpenAI API account with API billing configured

Open the project

- Start PyCharm and choose File > Open
- Select the Movie_Stills folder
- Let PyCharm finish indexing before installing packages

Create the environment

```
py -m venv .venv
.venv\Scripts\activate
python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
python movie_still_finder.py
```

If py is unavailable

Try python instead. If neither command works, reinstall Python with Add Python to PATH enabled.

PyCharm interpreter

Open Settings > Project > Python Interpreter, choose Add Local Interpreter > Existing, then select .venv\Scripts\python.exe.

4. Configure the OpenAI API key

Recommended: PyCharm environment variable

- Open Run > Edit Configurations
- Select Movie Still Finder
- Open Environment variables
- Add OPENAI_API_KEY and paste the key as its value
- Leave Store as project file unchecked
- Apply and run

Alternative: local .env file

- Duplicate .env.example
- Rename the copy to .env
- Replace the placeholder with the real key
- Never commit .env to GitHub

Get a key

Create and manage keys at platform.openai.com/api-keys. A full secret is shown only when it is created, so save it securely.

Billing

API billing is separate from a ChatGPT subscription. Manage API billing in the OpenAI platform billing settings.

Security rules

- Never paste a key into the Python source
- Never put a real key in .env.example
- Never include it in screenshots or chat
- If exposed, revoke it and create a replacement

What the app sends

The app sends sampled JPEG frames and your prompt to the OpenAI API. It does not upload the original movie file.

5. First run: the normal workflow

1	Load movies Use Add files for one or many selections, or Add folder to scan a folder and its subfolders.
2	Choose output The default is beside the first selected movie. Use Choose to change the destination.
3	Select a movie Click a movie in the list to load its preview, timeline, and clip details.
4	Describe the still Write a concrete prompt such as: close-up face, direct eye contact, sharp focus, dark background.
5	Choose sampling Use seconds for broad scans or frames for precise short clips. Smaller intervals send more images and cost more.
6	Find markers Search the selected video or every loaded video. Yellow markers appear on each movie's timeline.
7	Review and adjust Scrub, play, jump between markers, add missing markers, and remove weak ones.
8	Extract Click Extract marked stills. The app exports marked frames from all loaded movies.

6. Two kinds of AI assistance

Find markers

Use this when you already know what you want.

- Uses the prompt at the bottom of the window
- Uses the seconds/frame interval and confidence setting
- Can search one selected video or all loaded videos
- Creates timeline markers for matching sampled frames

Best for

Repeatable searches such as close-ups, handstands, smiles, product shots, or a specific costume.

GPT review selected

Use this when you want broader recommendations and analysis.

- Reviews one selected movie
- Uses Smart adaptive or Evenly spaced sampling
- Returns visual summary, candidate timestamps, suggested prompts, and composition notes
- Supports follow-up questions
- Can convert recommended timestamps into markers

Best for

Exploration, ranking, creative direction, and discovering moments you did not specify in advance.

Important

Neither mode scans every frame unless your frame interval is 1 and the clip is short enough. Results are limited by the frames sampled and sent to the model.

7. Sampling, markers, and exact frames

Seconds versus frames

- Every N seconds is simple for longer clips
- Every N frames is precise for short clips
- At 24 FPS: 1 frame = 0.041667 sec; 3 frames = 0.125 sec
- Smaller intervals improve coverage but increase API image inputs

Confidence

Higher values produce fewer, stricter matches. Lower values produce more candidates to review manually.

Marker behavior

- Double-click the timeline to add
- Right-click near a marker to remove
- Previous/Next wraps at the ends
- Clear all markers affects the selected movie
- First/last markers remain when Include first and last frames is enabled

Endpoint accuracy

First and last frames use exact frame-number decoding rather than timestamp seeking, avoiding compressed-video rounding near clip boundaries.

Practical starting point

For a 15-20 second clip, try every 6-12 frames first. If a brief moment is missed, reduce the interval and search again.

8. Multiple movies and extraction

Search all loaded videos

- Add a folder or multi-select files
- Set one prompt and sampling interval
- Click Find markers - all videos in folder
- Each movie keeps its own marker list
- Click each movie to inspect and edit its results

What 'all videos' means

It means every movie currently visible in the Movies list, including individually added files. It is not limited to files added through Add folder.

Extract marked stills

- Extraction processes all loaded movies
- Manual, AI, GPT-recommended, and enabled endpoint markers are exported
- Output filenames identify the source movie and time
- Choose a dedicated output folder to keep results together

Before extraction

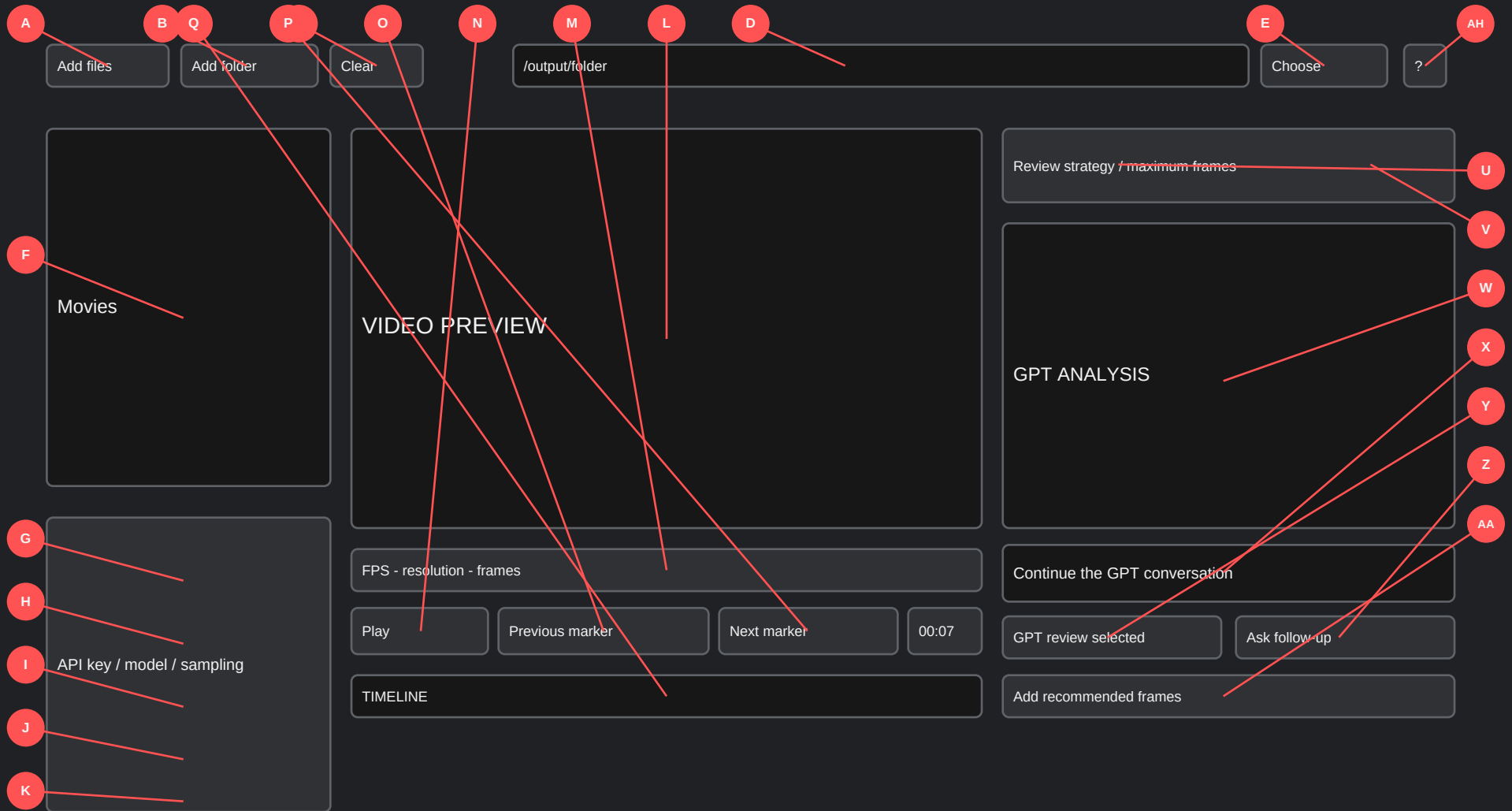
Review each movie, remove weak markers, confirm the output path, and verify first/last-frame behavior.

Source safety

The app reads movie files and writes separate still images. It does not alter or delete source movies.

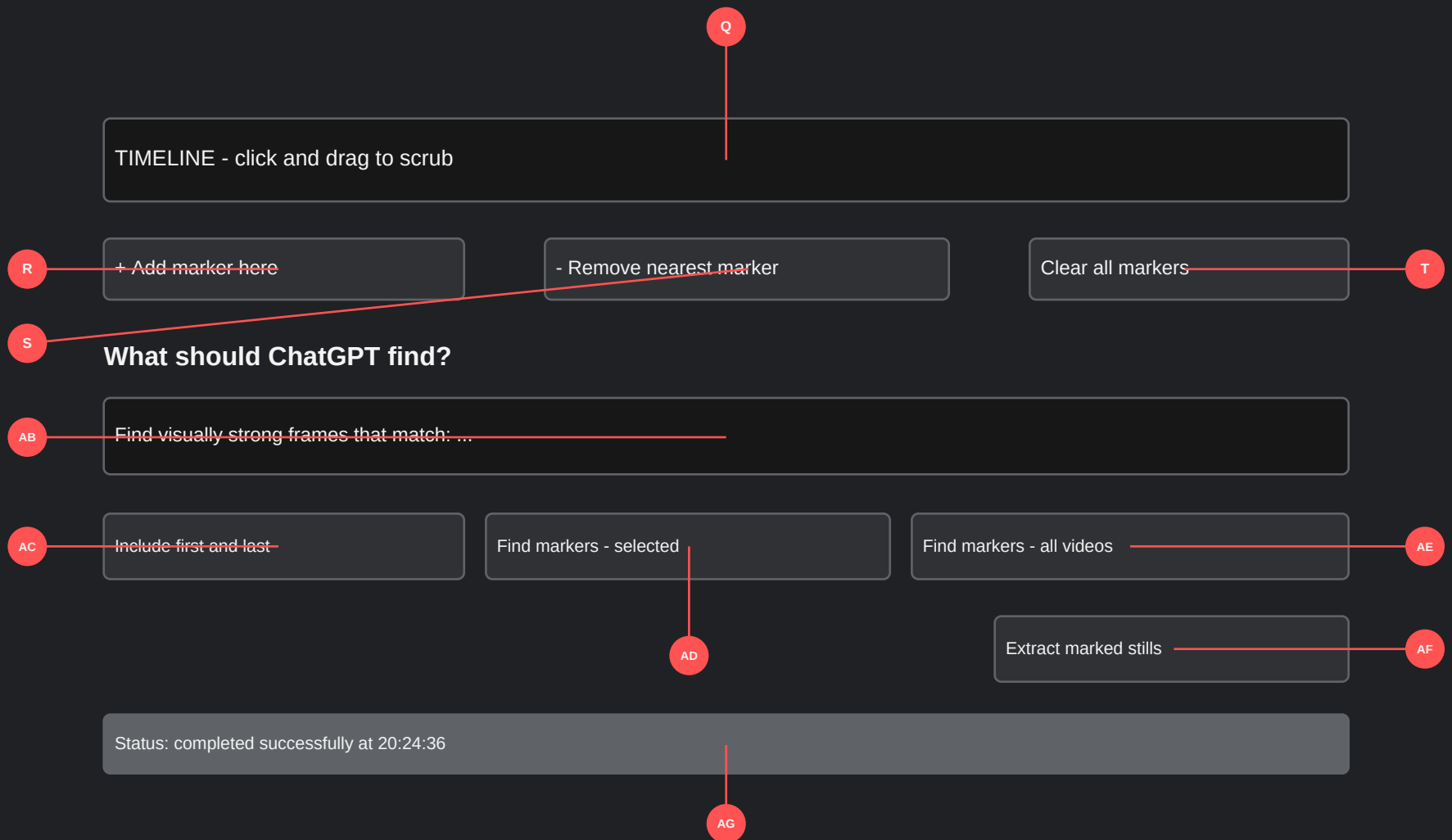
9. GUI map: complete workspace

Red callouts correspond to the alphabetical index on pages 12-13.



10. GUI map: timeline, search, and export

Use these controls to refine exactly which frames will be saved.



11. GUI index A-Q

A	Add files	Choose one or several movie files and add them to the Movies list.
B	Add folder	Find supported movie files inside a folder and its subfolders.
C	Clear	Remove all loaded movies from the app; source files are never deleted.
D	Output	Shows the folder where extracted still images will be saved.
E	Choose	Select a different output folder.
F	Movies	Lists loaded movies. Select one to show its preview, timeline, and markers.
G	OpenAI API key	Uses OPENAI_API_KEY from the environment or accepts a key for this run.
H	Model	Chooses the OpenAI vision model used for searches and reviews.
I	Every N seconds	Samples the movie at the entered number of seconds.
J	Every N frames	Samples every entered number of frames.
K	Confidence	Keeps GPT marker matches at or above this score.
L	Video preview	Displays the selected movie at the playhead position.
M	Clip details	Shows FPS, resolution, total frames, and seconds per frame.
N	Play / Pause	Starts or pauses playback of the selected movie.
O	Previous marker	Jumps to the previous marker and wraps at the beginning.
P	Next marker	Jumps to the next marker and wraps at the end.
Q	Timeline	Click or drag to scrub. Yellow markers are chosen frames; blue is the playhead.

12. GUI index R-AH

R	Add marker here	Adds a manual marker at the current playhead.
S	Remove nearest marker	Removes the marker nearest to the playhead.
T	Clear all markers	Clears non-endpoint markers from the selected movie.
U	Review strategy	Smart adaptive favors visual changes plus coverage; Evenly spaced uses uniform gaps.
V	Maximum frames	Limits the sampled frames GPT sees in a selected-movie review.
W	GPT analysis	Displays GPT summaries, recommendations, timestamps, and composition notes.
X	Continue conversation	Enter a question or instruction about the current review.
Y	GPT review selected	Reviews one selected movie using the review sampling controls.
Z	Ask follow-up	Sends the conversation text as a follow-up to the current review.
AA	Add recommended frames	Converts timestamps in the GPT review into timeline markers.
AB	What should ChatGPT find?	Describe the subjects, poses, framing, action, or visual qualities wanted.
AC	Include first and last frames	Keeps endpoint markers visible and includes them in extraction.
AD	Find markers - selected video	Searches sampled frames only in the highlighted movie.
AE	Find markers - all videos	Runs the same marker search on every loaded movie.
AF	Extract marked stills	Exports marked frames from all loaded movies to the output folder.
AG	Status bar	Reports progress, results, errors, and completion timestamps.
AH	Help (?)	Opens the searchable in-app guide; click again or use Close help to hide it.

13. Troubleshooting and maintenance

The app will not start

- Confirm the correct .venv interpreter is selected
- Run `python -m pip install -r requirements.txt`
- Read the first red error in PyCharm's Run pane

API key is missing

- Check the variable name is exactly `OPENAI_API_KEY`
- Run from the saved PyCharm configuration
- Do not enable Store as project file

No markers appear

- Lower confidence
- Use a smaller sample interval
- Make the prompt more visual and specific
- Confirm API billing and internet access

Playback or frame issues

- Try a common MP4 or MOV codec
- Confirm OpenCV installed successfully
- Test another clip to isolate a damaged file

Regular GitHub backup

- Press `Cmd+K` on macOS or `Ctrl+K` on Windows
- Review changed files
- Write a concise commit message
- Choose Commit and Push

Never commit

`.env`, `.idea`, `venv`, `.venv`, API keys, private movies, or output stills unless you deliberately want them in the repository.

Official references

OpenAI API keys: help.openai.com/en/articles/4936850 | API billing: help.openai.com/en/articles/9039756 | Python: python.org/downloads | GitHub repository: github.com/alenknight/Movie_Stills